

Voice of the Practitioner

What 203 lawyer-authored threads say about the legal-AI landscape — and where the product gap is

203

source records, deduplicated

17

practitioner subreddits

116

records dated March–August 2026

117

graded high confidence at capture

What this evidence is — and is not

Each record is one Reddit thread, deduplicated across 16 discovery passes and graded at capture.

A record IS

- A dated, linked, lawyer-authored account of a task attempted with a named tool
- Captured with the poster's role, firm size, task, outcome and a verbatim excerpt
- Labelled high, medium or low confidence when it was collected

A record is NOT

- A verified product fact, a benchmark, or a controlled head-to-head test
- A representative sample — posters self-select, and skeptics post more
- Free of vendor participation, which some threads disclose and others do not

116

records carry an ISO date between March and August 2026 — this reads the market as it is now

71%

of records come from r/legaltech, r/biglaw and r/Lawyertalk

11

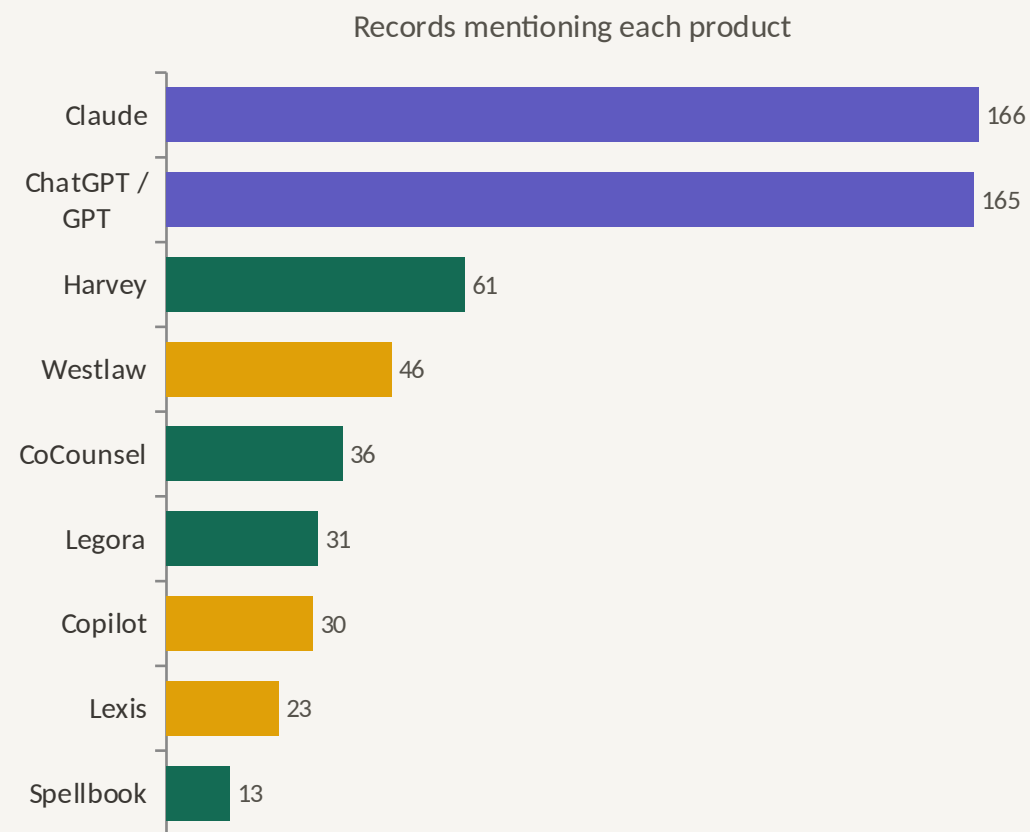
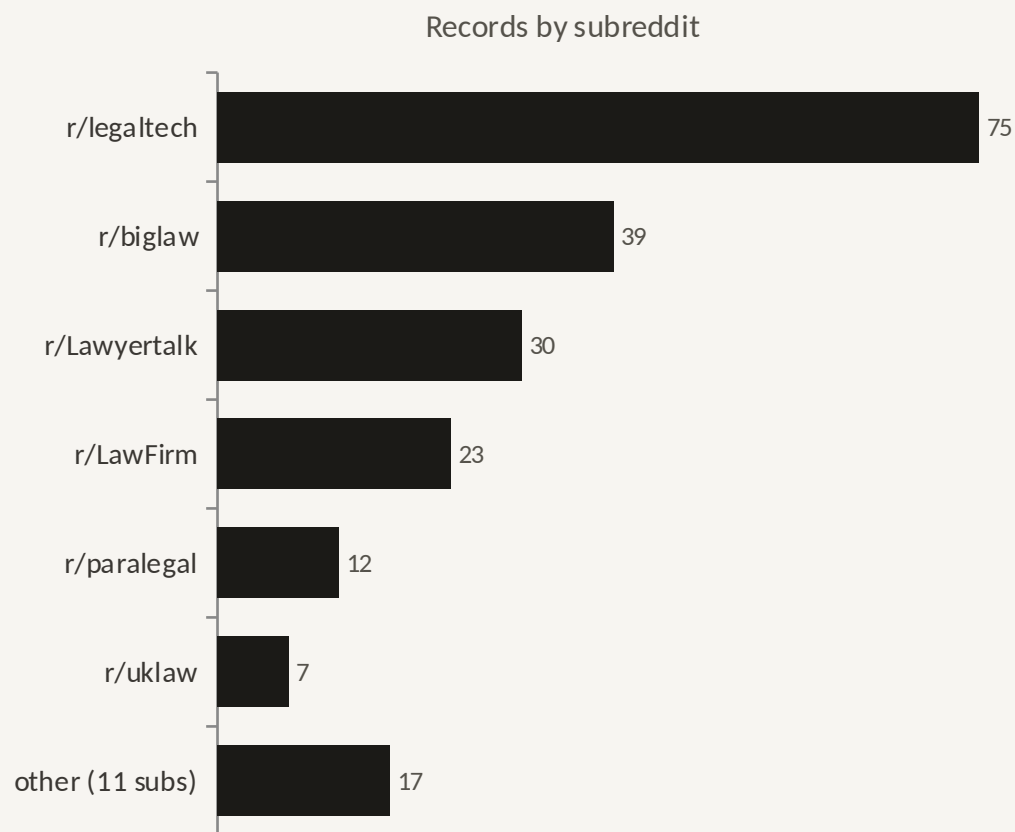
threads were removed or deleted and carry title-level signal only

0

controlled benchmarks with matched prompts across vendors

Where the conversation lives, and who gets named

Practitioner subreddits dominate. Two general models are named more often than every legal-AI platform combined.



Three tiers — and none of them owns the middle

Practitioners describe a clean division of labour, plus a gap nobody fills.



General frontier models

Claude • ChatGPT • Gemini

Wins on

Cheapest, most flexible, best-reported drafting and synthesis. \$20–\$200/mo.

Loses on

No grounded citations. No in-document workflow. Context dies with the chat.



Legal AI platforms

Harvey • CoCounsel • Legora • Spellbook

Wins on

Turnkey workflows, review tables, Word and DMS integration, legal data licences.

Loses on

Cannot demonstrate a model-quality edge. \$399–\$1,200/seat/mo with lock-in.



Incumbent databases

Westlaw • Lexis • vLex

Wins on

The only tier practitioners will cite from. Source-linked and verifiable.

Loses on

Their own AI layers are widely distrusted; retrieval-only, no work product.

The gap: no tier owns the work between an ambiguous request and a filed work product — the facts, the playbook, the prior decision, the draft and the record of what was decided.

Platforms cannot prove a model-quality edge

Nine records call the specialist products wrappers outright. The more damaging evidence is from buyers who chose one anyway.

“We couldn’t prove that the AI answers are consistently better than ChatGPT — UI features such as Word integration, access to legal databases etc.”

Corporate legal department evaluator, who bought Harvey anyway • reddit-103

“Their workflow is the difference maker. You could build it yourself but you would have to get big into an agent harness library like Mastra to get equivalent results.”

Legal-operations buyer comparing Harvey with base models • reddit-144

- **A firm’s Harvey ships a model picker.** “My firm’s version of Harvey has a button where you can select from a wide array of current and previous ChatGPT, Claude, and Google Gemini models.” (reddit-085)
- **The harness can subtract value.** “Even when you choose opus 5 as a model they somehow nerf it.” — a BigLaw associate comparing Harvey with Claude Code (reddit-096)
- **Harvey has conceded the critique.** In August 2026 Harvey announced Tenet, its first proprietary legal model, after building “on top of other companies’ AI models.” (reddit-173)
- **The verdict travels.** “Most legal AI software being a reskinned ChatGPT.” (reddit-199) • “Leya and Harvey? Overpriced Silicon Valley toys.” (reddit-104)

So what for Themis.ai: differentiation cannot be the model, and buyers already know it. It has to be the object the work lives in.

Price is the wedge — and the numbers are public

39 of 203 records raise cost as a decision factor. Practitioners now publish quotes, minimum seat counts and lock-in terms in the open.

\$1,200

per seat / month — Harvey’s opening quote to a large sub-AmLaw firm; \$2,400 with Lexis integration, later retiered near \$399

reddit-117

\$425

per seat / month — Harvey, 5-seat minimum, 12-month lock-in, quoted to a legaltech buyer

reddit-163

~\$30k

per year — Harvey, rejected by a 3-attorney legal department after a same-prompt comparison

reddit-110

\$200

per month — Claude with custom skills, legal connectors and proper context, reported as working “quite well”

reddit-154

- **Trials are the friction, not the sticker.** Harvey “seem to demand a minimum number of licenses, for a minimum 12-month period” (reddit-105, ~200 lawyers) • a small California firm found “no real path to try it” (reddit-107)
- **The real cost is downstream.** “At small firms the seat license is the cheapest part of the line item, integration debt is what eats the budget.” (reddit-129, 62 buyer assessments)

So what for Themis.ai: a self-serve, low-integration-debt product with no seat minimum is a category the corpus says does not exist.

Trial the platforms, then build your own

38 of 203 records describe internal or custom tooling. The most recent are post-trial decisions, not idle speculation.

“We had access to each system for ~3 weeks. We did discovery, a motion, and a memo. [All three missed a material heirship issue.] The only one that caught it without further prompting was Claude Opus.”

Head of technology, ~30-attorney firm, after trialling CoCounsel, Harvey and Legora — now building internally • reddit-175, 30 Aug 2026

- **A second firm reached the same decision.** “We just went through a whole process trialing Harvey, legora, and cocounsel. We decided ... it would be better for us to build our own practice area focused tool for a lot cheaper.” (reddit-174)
- **A 100+ lawyer firm chose the base model.** The technology committee largely selected Claude Enterprise firm-wide plus a small local research tool; an earlier Harvey trial “didn’t justify the cost.” (reddit-168)
- **In-house counsel are shipping their own.** “I’ve spent ... the last month building some AI tools to handle different rote parts of my job: NDA review, reg FD review, disclosure benchmarking ... They’re working well now.” (reddit-070)
- **And they are fast.** A lawyer rebuilt a failed automation in a day with Claude Code: “521 requirements extracted, full assessment engine, Word output with track changes and marginal comments.” (reddit-120)

Counter-evidence, stated plainly: a 150+ lawyer firm chose a domain-specific product because it was easier for the whole team (reddit-168); Claude Enterprise was rejected at a larger firm because “the skills aren’t real workflows” (reddit-147); and fixed terms, infosec and DPIAs slow every switch (reddit-146).

What is broken is the container, not the intelligence

Practitioners describe the same four failures regardless of which tool they use. All four are properties of the workspace, not the model.

“Lawyers need workspaces tied to matters, not chat sessions tied to nothing.”

[r/legaltech, on connecting Claude to CoCounsel](#) • reddit-140

“Each member just creates a Claude chat and uploads the contract, the playbook, and any additional context needed ...”

[An in-house contract team describing its actual process](#) • reddit-132

■ Context is re-uploaded every time

A Claude Project loaded with the playbook, form NDA and negotiation history became “extremely effective” — after setup. The setup is the barrier. (reddit-127)

■ Decisions are never recorded

“AI flagging clauses but no way to track decisions or reasons” — alongside contracts waiting in inboxes and no process visibility. (reddit-135)

■ The work never enters the lawyer’s tools

39 records name Word, Outlook, iManage, NetDocuments or SharePoint. Spellbook is preferred by one buyer for one reason: “it works inside Word.” (reddit-014)

■ The models are not the constraint

“The ai models are there already; they just need to be applied to your specific situation.” (reddit-106)

So what for Themis.ai: a durable matter that holds facts, playbooks, prior decisions, documents and provenance is the product. The model is a setting.

Verification is the unpriced cost that eats the time saving

The most consistent finding in the corpus. It is also the one that turns a productivity claim into a liability claim.

61 of 203

records state that output must be independently verified before it can be used — 30% of the corpus, across every tool tier

- **It is now producing sanctions.** An attorney was sanctioned \$8,000 and his firm \$2,500 for fake citations (reddit-051); Sullivan & Cromwell apologised to a judge for fabricated cases (reddit-071).
- **Careful review still fails.** “Did a cite check and found a bunch of issues, but I missed that AI had hallucinated an entire statutory provision.” (reddit-081)
- **The tax can exceed the saving.** “This leads to a situation where the time spent on a task is effectively doubled.” (reddit-082)
- **It is a pipeline defect, not a model defect.** “If somewhere along the pipeline the prompt includes ‘you must provide a citation’, the LLM will happily provide one, and if it can’t find one it will make one up.” (reddit-133)

And the counterweight: “I can’t tell from AI that such a case does not exist, but I can often find that such a case does exist in about 5 minutes rather than in 1–35 hours.” (reddit-141) — the value is in orientation and retrieval, provided the tool never asks to be trusted as the record.

So what for Themis.ai: make provenance and review state first-class fields. A machine claim and a human record must never look alike on screen.

22 records specifically report hallucinated or fabricated authorities • “I’ve now seen bad citations from associates, opposing counsel, Chatgpt, Claude, legal AI...” (reddit-170)

The gate is where the data goes, not what it can do

21 records describe confidentiality, retention or privilege as the binding constraint. Several describe outright bans on capable tools.

“When you dig into why, the answer is almost never about the AI itself. It’s about where the data goes.”

On why enterprise legal teams stall procurement even after the NDA is signed • [reddit-139](#)

- **Bans are live, not theoretical** An Am Law 200 firm “has outright banned everything except for Westlaw ... and Co-Pilot.” (reddit-022) A UK firm: “Sites like ChatGPT/Claude are not permitted and copilot is disabled.” (reddit-200)
- **One incident closes the door** “We had someone paste a client contract into chatgpt ... we ended up just blocking chatgpt at the firewall and telling people to use the company approved tools only.” (reddit-191)
- **Partners, not IT, are the blocker** A 15-attorney firm: “The managing partner is fearful of putting client data into any LLM.” Commenters pointed to enterprise, local and purpose-built options. (reddit-025)
- **Closed systems get through** Where public models are barred, closed products such as Legora are permitted — the permission follows the data boundary, not the capability. (reddit-200)

So what for Themis.ai: a local-first, Markdown-on-disk, bring-your-own-provider architecture is not a feature — it is the thing that gets the meeting.

The underserved buyer is already insourcing

This is the segment Themis.ai names as its primary user. The corpus shows demand rising and supply priced or scoped out.

Demand is real and measured in dollars

- “I’d farm out commercial agreements and licensing to outside counsel for \$5k-\$10k a pop. now i just feed those into AI and spend a couple of hours on each one.” (reddit-086)
- “Big corporates ... are increasingly asking why they’re being billed 10 hours for document review that their in-house team could do in an afternoon with Claude.” (reddit-137)
- In-house teams expect the largest AI savings by insourcing formerly outsourced work (Bloomberg Law, reddit-100)

Supply does not reach them

- “Looking for a more general transactional legal AI that has a ‘vault’ like Harvey but for a handful of users and maybe not as pricey.” (reddit-152)
- “I run a small firm in California ... I was honestly shocked by how expensive and inflexible their pricing model is ... no real path to try it.” (reddit-107)
- Small firms report being offered only Word add-ins or litigation platforms — nothing that holds a matter (reddit-152)

“I work in a software company as a litigation lawyer and use AI heavily. I use AI for intake, triaging, and providing playbook answers to the most common disputes before they escalate.”

[A product-counsel workflow described in the buyer’s own words • reddit-162](#)

So what for Themis.ai: the stated primary user sits exactly where demand is loudest and supply is thinnest.

Cross-check on fit over price: “At small firms the seat license is the cheapest part of the line item, integration debt is what eats the budget.” (reddit-129, from 62 buyer assessments of solo and 1–5 attorney firms)

On the model question, the evidence does not settle

Practitioner reports split. That is the argument for making the provider a setting rather than a bet.



Reported in Claude's favour

- Claude Opus caught a material heirship issue that CoCounsel, Harvey and Legora all missed (reddit-175)
- "I used claude opus recently and it was so so so much better [than Copilot] and I will lateral if I have to." (reddit-078)
- "Claude is looking the best so far but that's because it asks for clarification when it doesn't know." (reddit-038, reddit-183)
- A partner reported Claude Business plus agents outperforming his paralegal-and-associate team on a \$100m mock loan, and beating CoCounsel (reddit-131)
- Claude Code judged materially better than Harvey's harness on the same underlying model (reddit-096)



Reported against it

- A GC ran Harvey, ChatGPT and Claude on identical prompts and preferred ChatGPT for reasoning, citations, Word documents and redlines (reddit-110)
- "Claude has an annoying 'personality' and is wrong more often than GPT even on the highest thinking levels." (reddit-164)
- Claude, Gemini and ChatGPT were all reported to miss crucial information on commercial review and summarisation (reddit-091)
- A 72-page merger-agreement first pass found all four tested models "usable" — cost, not quality, was the only clear differentiator (reddit-156)

Read: no model wins on the reported evidence, and the reports contradict each other within weeks. Themis.ai's provider-adapter layer — mock, OpenAI-compatible and per-agent model routing — is the architecturally correct response to a market that has not settled.

What the corpus asks for that Themis.ai has already built

Six demands recur across the evidence. Each is already implemented in the MVP.



The matter as the container

Three-pane matter workspace, Markdown matter records, file tree and matter-scoped chat — not a chat session tied to nothing.

reddit-140 • 132 • 135



Context that persists

Hot-loaded company profile, playbooks, memory, agents and workflows in a vault. The playbook is loaded once, not re-uploaded per chat.

reddit-127 • 132 • 135



Decisions recorded with reasons

Decision register with rationale, conditions, revisit dates and a deterministic staleness audit.

reddit-135



Machine claim ≠ human record

Distinct visual roles for agent-generated drafts and human-recorded facts; generated drafts stay labelled and attribution survives edits.

reddit-081 • 133 • 170



Redlines that come back as Word

Markdown comments and tracked changes with native DOCX and PDF review export.

reddit-127 • 132 • 171



No forced data egress

Local-first, Markdown on disk, rebuildable index, mock mode with no API key, and an outbound policy that keeps private matter context local.

reddit-139 • 025 • 191 • 200

What is not built yet — in build order

Ranked by how often the corpus names it as the reason a tool was rejected or distrusted.

1	Grounded citation layer	Connector to Westlaw, Lexis or vLex, or a verification gate that refuses to emit an unverified authority.	61 records demand verification; 22 report fabricated authorities. Without this, Themis.ai inherits the objection that broke trust in every general model.	Not built
2	Word, Outlook and DMS integration	In-place drafting and redlining where lawyers actually work; semantic search across the document system and email.	39 records. “Spellbook ... works inside Word” was decisive for one buyer (reddit-014); DMS search is named the top unmet BigLaw use (reddit-092).	Not built
3	Structured playbook and clause engine	Clause deviation detection, fallback positions and risk scoring against a stored playbook — not a prose prompt.	“Tools have structured areas for UI to insert your playbooks or clauses to check.” (reddit-158) “It does an even better job when playbooks guide the analysis.” (reddit-114)	Partial
4	Shared vault for a small team	Seats, permissions and a shared matter store for two to ten users.	“A ‘vault’ like Harvey but for a handful of users and maybe not as pricey.” (reddit-152) Matter-level controls are the partner’s condition (reddit-025).	Not built
5	External intake channels	Email, Slack and ticket intake into the matter, so work does not sit in an inbox waiting to be pasted.	“Contracts waiting in inboxes” is named as a core failure (reddit-135); lawyers work from email (reddit-106).	Partial
6	Packaged deployment and a data term sheet	A deployable build plus written answers on retention, training and disclosure, ready for infosec and DPIA review.	“Ask questions about pricing, data handling, what happens to your documents.” (reddit-159) Infosec and DPIAs are the stated switching delay (reddit-146).	Partial

All six sit on Themis.ai’s existing “Later” list. The corpus does not add scope — it orders it, and puts grounded citations first.

The market converged on the model layer and left the matter layer empty. Themis.ai is built on the matter layer.

What would change this reading

- A specialist platform publishing a matched-prompt benchmark it wins — none exists in 203 records
- Harvey's Tenet model closing the quality gap the wrapper critique opened (reddit-173)
- Frontier vendors shipping the matter object themselves, at which point this is a distribution race
- Enterprise procurement hardening around a short vendor list before small teams can self-serve

How much weight this evidence carries

- Self-selected practitioner reports — not a survey, not a controlled trial, and skeptics post more than satisfied users
- Confidence graded at capture: 117 high, 63 medium, 12 low, 11 unusable
- 71% of records come from three subreddits; BigLaw and legaltech are over-represented against small firms
- 116 records are dated March–August 2026 — a snapshot of now, not a trend line